



PHOTOS COURTESY OF **GUCCI OSTERIA**

Chefs are the new icons and aligning with their persona allows fashion brands to resonate with diverse demographics and entice potential consumers

The Anand-LV venture represents just one instance of fashion intersecting with food. Many luxury brands have ventured into culinary collaborations, such as Chanel's glitzy Beige restaurant led by chef Alain Ducasse in Tokyo, and Dior's upcoming Monsieur Dior restaurant in Japan, helmed by chef Anne-Sophie Pic. Meanwhile, Giorgio Armani boasts its own F&B vertical, with more than 20 outlets, including restaurants and cafes worldwide.

One particularly successful fu-

sion of fashion and food is Gucci's partnership with celebrity chef Massimo Bottura. In 2018, Bottura was brought on board to set up Gucci Osteria, a contemporary Italian eatery nestled adjacent to the Gucci Garden and boutique in the heart of Florence. The concept aimed to blend the sophistication and innovation of two iconic Italian brands, offering guests haute cuisine that lived up to Bottura's culinary reputation within a setting tastefully curated by Gucci.

Initially, the restaurant at-

tracted diners who were eager to experience Bottura's culinary genius. Those unable to secure a table at his three Michelin-starred Osteria Francescana, could dine at Gucci Osteria for less than half the cost. But, over time, Karime Lopez, head chef at the restaurant, crafted her own culinary identity, developing a loyal following and drawing in guests for her own distinctive creations.

This experiment proved so successful that the restaurant was awarded a Michelin star the following year. Gucci went on to open three more such restaurants in cities such as Tokyo, Seoul and Los Angeles, two of which also subsequently earned Michelin stars.

Gucci's collaboration with Bottura, both strategic and personal, leveraged the childhood friendship between former CEO Marco Bizzarri and the famous chef in a mutually beneficial manner.

Bottura's deep personal commitment to the project elevated the Gucci Osteria brand into an extension of his famed Osteria Francescana, maintaining the same exceptional standards of food and service. He personally selected and mentored chefs such as Lopez and Takahiko Kondo, Antonio Iacoviello, Mattia Agazzi and Hyungkyu Jun to lead the various branches worldwide. And the triumph of Gucci's collaboration with Bottura epitomises the seamless fusion of haute couture and haute cuisine.

So, will fashion brands continue to be a part of the culinary industry in the years to come? My guess is yes. Food has become the ultimate fashion statement, and the haute couture revolution in the kitchen is just getting started. **BT**

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